Office of Research Assurance

Human Subject Research Protections Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)

SOP-101: Cooperative Research – NASA as the Reviewing IRB

Number	Effective Date	Version Number	Previous Version
101	9/17/2025	v.4.3	v.4.2

Purpose

Human subjects research conducted at NASA frequently involves the collaboration of investigators outside of NASA. Given that institutions have oversight responsibility for their respective researchers' activities, a project involving multiple researchers could result in the need for reviews by multiple IRB. In an effort to streamline the process, federal regulations [NASA 14 CFR 1230.114] have been enacted requiring that institutions engaged in cooperative research (i.e., non-exempt research involving more than one institution) establish provisions to avoid duplication of IRB review efforts while ensuring participant rights and welfare are protected.

The Office of Research Assurance (ORA) standard operating procedures (SOP) series 101-104 outlines the processes and criteria for establishing formal agreements between NASA and external institutions, universities, or individual investigators.

ORA:SOP-101 establishes the process and responsibilities when the NASA IRB serves as the *Reviewing IRB* (or IRB of Record) in a formal Reliance Acknowledgement (RA). RA are formal arrangements between the NASA IRB and an external institution's IRB. **ORA:SOP-102** outlines the process for the NASA IRB ceding oversight to an external IRB. Additional options for reducing oversight duplication for collaborators not affiliated with an institution holding a Federalwide Assurance (FWA) or for those located outside of the United States are detailed in **ORA:SOP-103** and **ORA:SOP-104,** respectively.

In general, NASA does not enter Reliance Acknowledgements with external institutions for research projects determined to be exempt according 14 CFR 1230.104(d), unless limited IRB review is required or for limited cases in which NASA determines an RA is otherwise appropriate.

Examples of collaborative relationships for which **ORA:SOP-101** may apply include:

- NASA Principal Investigators (PI) collaborating with external Co-Investigators (Co-I) or other external research team members to conduct research on NASA facilities or with NASA employees as subjects,
- External PI conducting research at NASA facilities or with NASA employees as subjects,
- External PI or Co-I who obtain, use, study, analyze, or generate identifiable private information about NASA employees for research purposes.

Policy

1. Any institutions or organizations holding an FWA engaged[1] in research for which the NASA IRB serves as the Reviewing IRB must have an executed IRB Reliance Acknowledgement (RA) with the NASA IRB. The RA specifies the institutional party to which the delegation of duties and responsibilities described in this policy apply.
2. The NASA Office of Research Assurance identifies the appropriate Reviewing IRB when NASA is supporting the research and engaged in research activities. [14 CFR 1230.114(b)(1)]
3. NASA IRB shall be the Reviewing IRB for:
    a. All human subject research performed on NASA property, including on spacecraft funded or supported by NASA or that use NASA resources[2]; or within NASA facilities, including the International Space Station (ISS) or NASA analog missions/environments.
    b. All human subject research intentionally using NASA employees as research subjects, including active flight or non-flight NASA astronauts.

    Note: the NASA IRB may be stipulated as the IRB of Record for collaborative research not meeting criteria (a) or (b) as a condition of funding or support, or as determined to be appropriate by NASA as established at 14 CFR 1230.114(b)(1).
4. The review performed by the NASA IRB will meet human subject protection requirements 14 CFR 1230, NPR 7100.1, NPD 7100.1, and FDA 21 CFR 50, 56, 312, and 812, as applicable.
5. The NASA IRB and Relying Site(s) shall comply with this SOP as well as the responsibilities listed in the Reliance Acknowledgement (RA) document and supplementary SOPs, policies, and requirements, as outlined in the executed RA.
6. The NASA IRB will consult with NASA Office of the General Counsel (OGC) for any substantive changes to the RA forms or policies.
7. The NASA IRB will follow written procedures for reporting its findings and actions to the appropriate officials at the collaborating Investigator's institution/Relying Site as described under "Responsibilities."

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[1] *In general, an institution is considered engaged in a particular non-exempt human subjects research project when its employees or agents for the purposes of the research project obtain: (1) data about the subjects of the research through intervention or interaction with them; (2) identifiable private information about the subjects of the research; or (3) the informed consent of human subjects for the research.* [OHRP: Engagement of Institutions in Human Subjects Research (2008)]

[2] *Note: NASA resources related to operation of the commercial facility, aircraft, or spacecraft having nothing to do with the human research activity does not constitute "use of NASA resources" for the actual human research activity. For example, if the institution or commercial provider only uses KSC services to launch the vehicle, this policy would not apply.* [NPD 7100.1]

Responsibilities

The **NASA IRB Office within the Office of Research Assurance (ORA)** is responsible for ensuring the procedures listed in this policy are executed accurately and efficiently.

NASA IRB as the Reviewing IRB

Responsibilities of ***NASA IRB as the Reviewing IRB*** include, but are not limited to:

1. Working in collaboration with the Point of Contact (POC) at the Relying Site to determine and document specific roles and responsibilities for communicating key information with the Relying Site and the NASA IRB.
2. Providing notification to the overall Principal Investigator (PI) of:
    a. the NASA IRB's decision to approve or disapprove the research,
    b. any IRB required modifications to secure approval of the research, and
    c. the date by which renewal of an approval (i.e., continuing review or other update) is required.
3. Maintaining IRB documentation relevant to the research, including, but not limited to:
    a. NASA IRB submission materials,
    b. protocol review determinations (approvals and disapprovals, stipulations, or modifications requests), and
    c. NASA IRB meeting minutes.
4. Upon reasonable request, providing the Relying Site with access to relevant records related to the IRB review.
5. Notifying the overall PI, and when applicable the Relying Site, of the lapse in IRB approval and any applicable corrective action plans.
6. Promptly notifying the overall PI, and when applicable the Relying Site, of any finding of serious and or/continuing noncompliance that may affect the conduct of the research or the safety, rights, or welfare of human subjects.
7. Providing acknowledgement of study closure to the overall PI and to the POC for the Relying Site IRB.

Relying Site

Responsibilities of ***Relying Site*** include, but are not limited to:

1. Communication of any local context issues relevant to the research protocol to the NASA IRB. The Relying Site is specifically responsible for:
    a. Ensuring that information regarding local considerations is communicated to the NASA IRB, including requirements of applicable state or local laws, regulations, policies, and ancillary review processes relevant to the specific study(s) ceded to NASA IRB.

i. When applicable, providing the NASA IRB information about local regulations and/or requested substitutions to informed consent documents, including institution-specific language (e.g., the relying institution's standard injury compensation language, if research is conducted at the site).

2. Abiding by their site's requirements with regard to ceded review, such as ensuring other reviews or signoffs required by the institution have been completed before a study is activated.
3. Confirming and retaining documentation that all collaborating site research personnel are appropriately qualified and eligible to conduct research, (e.g., human subjects protection training, conflict of interests are appropriately handled).
    a. This documentation shall be provided to the NASA IRB upon request in sufficient detail to facilitate IRB review and oversight of the study.
    b. **Conflicts of Interest** (COI) must be reported to NASA IRB for site investigators/personnel for consideration.
        i. Investigators/personnel must promptly report to their Site and to the NASA IRB any changes in COI disclosures and resulting changes in COI management plans related to the research under the RA.
        ii. When relevant, information about COI management plans for site personnel shall be provided to the NASA IRB in sufficient detail for IRB review and oversight of the study.
4. Maintenance of an OHRP-approved FWA and notify NASA IRB promptly in writing of any suspension, restriction, termination, or expiration of said FWA.
5. The Relying Site may choose to perform its own local review, as complies with their institution's policies.
    a. Research may be disapproved by officials of the Relying Site; however, may not approve the research that has not been approved by NASA IRB when NASA is serving as the IRB of Record.
6. The Relying Site will assure research personnel are notified of their responsibilities when conducting research pursuant to the applicable RA and this SOP.
7. When applicable, the Relying Site will assure that the research team is conducting research and recruiting potential research participants in accordance with NASA IRB-approved protocol, procedures, and documents.
8. The Relying Site and its researchers acknowledge that they are responsible for safeguarding the rights and welfare of each research participant, and that the participant's rights and welfare must take precedence over the goals and requirements of the research.
9. If the Relying Site is a covered entity responsible for HIPAA-compliant research, the NASA IRB will defer to the Relying Site's SOPs on meeting those provisions (including, but not limited to authorizations, notices of decedent research, and Limited Data Set with Data Use Agreements).
    a. Note: the NASA IRB is not a HIPAA covered entity.

10. The Relying Site retains responsibility for investigating allegations of research misconduct of its own investigators, for taking appropriate action consistent with their institutional policy, and promptly notifying the NASA IRB of any relevant actions or determinations.
11. ***Reporting Requirements*** - The Relying Site agrees to facilitate the NASA IRB's responsibility for initial and continued review, record keeping, and reporting requirements. All information requested or required by the NASA IRB will be reported in a timely manner.
    a. The Relying Site shall notify the NASA IRB of any legal request (e.g., subpoena, open records request) connected to the study and reasonably assist with investigations and response to such requests as mutually determined to be lawful and appropriate.
        i. The Relying Site will also notify the NASA IRB of audits (including findings and corrective actions), communications with regulatory agencies, or findings of research misconduct.
    b. The Relying Site shall provide cooperation with and necessary reports for any audit or investigation of any matter related to the research study for which NASA IRB is serving as the IRB of Record.

Overall PI Responsibilities

Responsibilities of the Overall Principal Investigator (PI), include but are not limited to:

1. Overall management and oversight of the research at all sites.
2. Safeguarding the rights and welfare of each research participant.
3. Ensuring safe and appropriate conduct of research including, but not limited to:
    a. monitoring protocol compliance,
    b. ensuring all collaborators and study staff are appropriately qualified, have completed Human Subjects Protections training, and have been adequately trained to conduct the study in alignment with the IRB approved protocol.
4. Promptly report to the NASA IRB, the following information in accord with all published NASA IRB policies and procedures, including, but not limited to:
    a. Any changes in funding
    b. Changes in Conflicts of Interest, including institutional and potential financial interest, related, or potentially related to research
    c. Proposed changes or modifications to the approved research protocol, including the research plan, consent process and form, and/or methods of recruitment
    d. Continuing reviews and/or progress reports
    e. Reports of New Information (RNI) including, but not limited to:
        i. Deviations from the approved protocol
        ii. Noncompliance
        iii. Subject injuries/adverse events related to the research, or significant complaints that could affect the conduct of the research.
        iv. Unanticipated Problems Involving Risks to Subjects or Others (UPIRSOs)

f. When more than one site has been approved for reliance on NASA IRB for the same research study, the Overall PI must:

   i. Promptly respond to questions or requests for information from other Investigators and/or study teams at Relying Sites.

   ii. Participate in conference calls regarding the study as requested by the NASA IRB.

   iii. Provide NASA IRB contact information and NASA IRB policies to the Site Investigators.

   iv. Provide documentation of study-wide IRB determinations to Relying Sites.

   v. Provide other Relying Site(s) with the NASA IRB-approved versions of all study-wide documents (e.g., consent and authorization forms, protocol, recruitment materials).

   vi. Provide updated copies of the modified versions of study-wide IRB-approved materials to Relying Site(s) in a timely manner.

   vii. Provide access, upon request, to study records for audit by the Relying Site(s), the NASA IRB, and other regulatory or monitoring entities.

   viii. Follow all requirements of the Relying Site(s) regarding ceded review, such as ensuring administrative requirements for documenting ceded review have been met before study activation occurs at a Relying Site.

   ix. Obtain and collate study-wide information for continuing review and submission to NASA IRB.

   x. Provide NASA with a closure request form and verify closure of all sites when a study is closed.

Procedures

Coordination of the RA process is subject to many complicating factors. In general, NASA IRB staff adhere to the following procedures as outlined below. However, there may be situations in which the NASA IRB staff, with concurrence of the Office of Research Assurance (ORA) Director, must exercise flexibility when executing Reliance. ORA may consult with the NASA Office of the General Counsel (OGC) as appropriate.

NASA IRB as the Reviewing IRB - Reliance Acknowledgement (RA)

1. Requests for the NASA IRB to serve as the Reviewing IRB are integrated into the eIRB submission process.
2. Prior to submitting to the NASA IRB, external investigators should contact their home institution's IRB to ascertain reliance-related procedures.
   a. A Point of Contact (POC) for the external IRB/Relying Site should be identified and communicated to the NASA IRB office.
3. When the PI of the study is external to NASA, the RA is established concurrently with IRB review of the study.

a. In general, final approval of a study will not be released until the RA[3] for an overall PI external to NASA is fully executed.

b. Investigators for additional external/relying sites *engaged* in human subjects research activities may be added to the study via modification once the RA for the PI's site is established.

c. Only one primary site investigator is listed for each external relying site on the NASA IRB application.

i. Confirmation of qualifications and assessment of COI for additional personnel at a site are the responsibility of the Relying Site.

4. Upon receiving a request that the NASA IRB serve as the Reviewing IRB, the **NASA IRB Office** will:

a. Begin the IRB pre-review process to assure the research project is complete and meets NASA IRB Office pre-review requirements.

b. Establish Points of Contact (POC) at the external sites using POC provided by the PI.

i. The overall PI and Relying Site(s) investigator(s) are copied on correspondence with the Relying Sites.

c. Complete the necessary information pertaining to NASA IRB's role in the acknowledgement.

d. Provide the Relying Site with the NASA RA form and applicable SOP and forms.

e. Upon receipt of the partially executed RA form, NASA IRB staff:

i. Confirm that the Relying Site(s) can fulfill the responsibilities as outlined in the RA and related SOP.

ii. Send the partially executed RA form to the Office of the Chief Health and Medical Officer (OCHMO) designee for signature.

f. Upon receipt of the fully executed RA form, NASA IRB Staff:

i. Forward the fully executed RA form to the Relying Site's IRB, Relying Investigator(s), and the overall PI.

ii. Ensure executed RA are uploaded to the eIRB system once received from OCHMO.

5. Documentation related to the reliance is included within the study's eIRB.

a. A completed reliance form from each collaborating institution holding an FWA, signed by the Relying Site's responsible Institutional Official or designee.

i. An executed RA covers all collaborating investigators affiliated with the relying institution.

6. Terminating the Acknowledgement(s)

a. The RA is in effect once fully executed by both the NASA IRB and the Relying Site and continues until the study is closed by the NASA IRB.

[3] or alternate arrangements pursuant to 14 CFR 1230.114(b)(2)(ii) as determined by the NASA IRB

b. The NASA IRB, as the Reviewing IRB, may terminate an RA through written notification of termination to the Relying Site including the effective end date and reason for termination.

c. If the Relying Site is no longer participating, a modification indicating removal of the site must be submitted through the NASA eIRB system.

i. The modification should include information about the reason for termination of the RA and any potential impacts on research activities or data protection.

ii. Termination of one participating site will not terminate the RA of remaining participating sites or institutions.

7. The NASA IRB, the overall PI, Relying Sites and collaborating Investigators will cooperate and establish effective communication and documentation practices so that all responsibilities outlined by this policy may be fulfilled.

Definitions

Cooperative Research: non-exempt human subjects research that involves more than one institution *engaged* in the research.

Engaged:[4] NASA is considered engaged in human subjects research requiring NASA IRB review when:

1. NASA's employees or agents obtain:
   a. data about the participants of the research through intervention or interaction with them,
   b. identifiable private information or identifiable biospecimens about the participants of research, or
   c. the informed consent of human subjects for the research.
2. Human subjects research per 14 CFR 1230/21 CFR 56:
   a. is conducted under a contract or Space Act Agreement identifying NASA IRB as the IRB of Record,
   b. is conducted on NASA property,
   c. includes NASA employees or agents as study participants,
   d. uses NASA employees' or agents' identifiable private information or identifiable biospecimens, or
   e. uses identifiable private information or identifiable biospecimens from NASA repositories.

Institution [14 CFR 1230.102]: any public or private entity or agency (including federal, states, and other agencies).

Reviewing IRB: The "IRB of Record" to which authority for IRB review and oversight has been ceded by the Relying IRB or Relying Site.

Study Personnel: In addition to the PI, those involved in the conduct of human subject research in which the persons engaged are in direct contact with research participants consenting and/or collecting data, and/or have access to private and identifiable research data.

[4] [OHRP: Engagement of Institutions in Human Subjects Research (2008)]

Noncompliance: Conducting human subjects research in such a way that disregards or violates (1) the applicable laws, regulations, or NASA policies governing human subject research, or (2) the requirements or determinations of the NASA Institutional Review Board (IRB).

Overall Principal Investigator (PI): The lead principal investigator with ultimate responsibility for conduct and integrity of the research at all sites.

Principal Investigator (PI): The NASA PI or an external PI that is responsible for coordination with the NASA IRB or the IRB of Record for all of the research sites.

Reliance Acknowledgement (RA): An agreement or 'acknowledgement' entered into by two or more institutions engaged in human subjects research that permits one or more institutions to cede IRB review to another IRB. The signed acknowledgement permits a single IRB to review human subject research activities for more than one site and documents respective authorities, roles, responsibilities, and communication between an organization providing the ethical review and a participating organization relying on a reviewing IRB.

Relying IRB: The local IRB of an institution or organization that has ceded IRB review to another IRB to provide IRB review and oversight for a specific study or set of studies.

Relying Site (Relying Institution): The research site(s) at an institution or organization that has ceded to another institution's IRB to provide review and oversight for a specific study or set of studies. This includes institutions who have ceded IRB Review through an executed Reliance Acknowledgement or collaborating investigators at external sites who have signed Individual Investigator Acknowledgements with the IRB of Record.

Site Investigator (local Investigator): The investigator at one of the sites where the study is occurring and is responsible to PI.

Unanticipated Problem Involving Risks to Subjects or Others (UPIRSO): [5] any incident, experience, or outcome that meets all of the following:

1. unexpected (in terms of nature, severity, or frequency) given (a) the procedures described in the research protocol documents, such as the IRB-approved research protocol and informed consent document; and (b) the characteristics of the human subject population being studied,
2. is related or possibly related to participation in the research, and
3. suggests that the research places human subjects or others at a greater risk of harm (including physical, psychological, economic, or social harm) related to the research than was previously known or recognized (even if no harm has actually occurred).

References

- 14 CFR 1230.114
- NPR 7100.1
- 45 CFR 46.103(e), 46.114
- 21 CFR 50, 56, 312, and 812
- ICH-GCP (E6)

[5] (Office for Human Research Protections (OHRP), 2007)

- AAHRPP Tip Sheet 24: Single IRB or EC Review
- NIH Policy on the Use of a Single Institutional Review Board for Multi-Site Research

Engagement of Institutions in Human Subjects Research U.S. Department of Health and Human Services: Office for Human Research Protections (OHRP) Regulations, Policy & Guidance. - October 16, 2008.

Extending an FWA to Cover Collaborating Investigators. U.S. Department of Health and Human Services: Office for Human Research Protections (OHRP) - January 31, 2005.

Reviewing and Reporting Unanticipated Problems Involving Risks to Subjects or Others and Adverse Events: OHRP Guidance U.S. Department of Health and Human Services: Office for Human Research Protections (OHRP) January 15, 2007.

Version #	Version Notes:	Originated By:	Approved By:	Date Approved:
V.4.3	Fixed formatting issues. Clarifications related to procedures for fully executed RA forms	J. Kissling, J. Green	M. Covington	17Sep2025
v.4.2	Updated engaged definition	J. Green, J. Ensley Gorshe	M. Covington	19Mar2025
v.4.1	Typographical correction; clarifications related to COI documentation	A. Garza, J. Ensley Gorshe	M. Covington	27Feb2025
v.4	Restructured RA series SOP: 100-104. Amended responsibility for COI/training for site personnel to Relying Site.	J. Ensley Gorshe/J. Green	M. Covington	22May2024
v.3	Substantive revisions to process.	P. Weitzel, J. Ensley Gorshe	M. Covington	28Mar2023
v.2		J. Kisenwether	M. Covington	12Nov2020
v.1		J. Christensen	M. Covington	07Jul2020